

foreign brokerage. Lucky repaid his debt to him by occasionally leaking to him information about big trades.

Burly and jovial, Lucky adopted a philosophy that was as earthy as his mannerisms.

‘It is God’s wish that I should make good money and enjoy life; that is why he put me in the stock market though I had no intention of coming to this industry,’ he once told me.

I found Lucky’s Pinglish (English with an unmistakable Punjabi accent) quite amusing, and more so when he ranted in English after downing a couple of pegs.

‘Everybody here is robbing in some way or the other; the only difference is that some do it in a sophisticated manner,’ he would say.

Lucky was aware of his limitations, perhaps the reason why he was so focused in the way he went about things. He was a good storyteller and I enjoyed the tales from his days as a struggler in the industry.

‘ . . . so there was this elderly fund manager in one of the PSU insurance firms. For some reason he took a liking to me and gave me orders occasionally. That helped me survive in my first job. But there was a price to pay for this kindness even though this gentleman was a much better person than some of his peers at other fund houses. As a token of gratitude, I decided to buy him a fancy bedcover from a friend who dealt in them. It was a beautiful piece – lovely embroidery on fine material – and every bit worth the Rs 1,500 I paid for it. The fund manager initially turned down my present, citing company rules. But when I opened it to show him the design and the feel, he was impressed.

‘Still, he maintained that his principles would not allow him to accept expensive gifts from brokers. I lied to him that it was not expensive at all. “I got a very good deal from my friend who deals in export seconds; only Rs 600, sir. That is not very expensive.” He accepted the gift and I was happy he liked it. But my happiness evaporated the following day when he called up saying his wife liked the piece so much she now wanted to present similar pieces to her parents and relatives who were coming down the following week.

‘He asked me, “Can you arrange for three of them for me, Lucky? I will pay you tomorrow itself.” I was caught in a web of my own making. I could not tell him the true price of that piece. I arranged for three more pieces; the fund manager never paid the Rs 1,800 he had promised. I consoled myself